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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

The 5 Deadly Sins of AI Agents: What I Learned Building One Marketing Agent Three Times

Date & time: Oct. 15, 10:00-10:35 AM
Track: Applied AI



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Session Description

Everyone has seen AI agents. Few marketing teams have seen them work. Sandy Carter, CEO of EQUS and author of AI First, Human Always, built the same content marketing agent three times: first on OpenClaw, then on Hermes, and finally on Claude. Each version taught a different lesson, and each lesson maps to one of the five deadly sins of AI agents: All Talk, All Access, Groundhog Day, Hot Mic and No Rehearsal.

You'll see how the agent is built, what it can and can't touch, and how its playbook gets better with every campaign. You'll leave with a working definition of an agent, a three-level permission model for your team, and a safe way to launch your first marketing agent on Monday.

Key Quote

> *"It's a machine; it's not a person, and it's going to apply what you say, not what you meant."*
> **- Sandy Carter**

Session Summary

Sandy Carter, CEO of EQUS, walked through the five deadly sins of AI agents and then showed, step by step, how she built an agent for her podcast, the AI Marketing Companion, which Mark Schaefer passed to her in January. She described an agent as autonomous: it pursues a goal, plans its own steps, connects to your tools and systems, and delivers reviewable work. With a story about a lopsided pancake, she stressed that agents today are at the "messy startup picture," not the perfect one.

Each sin came with a CMO's story. The double agent: a CMO alleged that after an agent built personas from her customer list, competitors began targeting those same customers. The skeleton key: an agent given a login to clean up a trade show list drafted an email to all 40,000 customers before it was stopped. The guest who never leaves: a team forgot to disconnect tools after a six-week campaign test, and the agent spent $60,000 the following quarter. The empty chair: research she did for Forbes found companies were far more successful when the C-suite

actively used the technology. For the fifth, she used her hole in one, which only counted once a witness signed for it, to argue that AI lacks a way to verify who approved an agent and whether it may act.

Carter first tried OpenClaw, which ran up about $700 in a weekend and made credentialing hard; Hermes, which lacked the connections she needed; and Meta Muse, which stored data with Meta, something her guests and sponsors rejected. She built the final agent on Claude in four steps. First, the brain: a Claude project documenting her 10-step podcast workflow, with approval gates and reusable skills. Second, context: her voice, audience, sponsor priorities, real examples, banned hype words and insider facts, with corrections, like changing a 10% to 14% open-rate gain the agent had described as a 40% boost, saved as reusable rules. Third, connectors to Riverside, Google Sheets, Brevo and Libsyn, the hardest part. Fourth, autopilot, using triggers and schedules, named outputs, stops for human approval and a log of every step.

After about three months, her podcast prep time fell from nine hours to three, guest booking dropped from four weeks to two hours, newsletter open rates rose from 10% to 14%, and the podcast has won five marketing podcast awards. She credited domain knowledge as the key skill, since the agent could only follow the steps she understood. She closed with a demo of what she sees as the future: her agent negotiating a guest's topic and time directly with that guest's agent, using time-limited credentials and without exposing private data, built on her company's platform rather than Claude.

In the Q&A, Carter advised checking every privacy setting in each tool, while cautioning that data is still hard to fully protect. For teams building an internal AI brain, she recommended deciding which knowledge stays with the company and which belongs to employees, starting in one function, and planning how the brain handles conflicting direction. Her biggest lesson: be precise and detailed in the instructions.

Key Takeaways

- **Guard against the double agent:** Check every privacy setting in each tool you use, knowing that even this may not fully protect your data.
- **Limit access and time:** Give agents only the access they need, and set dates and times on how long that access lasts.
- **Turn it off when you're done:** Disconnect tools after a test ends, or the agent can keep acting, and spending, on its own.
- **Start with the brain:** Document your workflow step by step before automating it, because domain knowledge is what makes an agent useful.
- **Turn corrections into rules:** Give the agent context like your voice, audience and banned words, and save each correction as a reusable rule.
- **Keep a human in the loop:** Build in approval stops and a log so you can review and verify every step the agent takes.